

Skills for Life

Rules and tools

**ESOL
Levels 1 and 2**

Introduction

These supplementary materials are a series of reference sheets designed to support and clarify some of the language and skills objectives addressed in the ESOL Skills for Life Entry 3 learner materials. They are available for the teacher to download and distribute to the learner as required.

Contents

- 1 The passive
- 2 Question tags
- 3 Connectives
- 4 Present perfect continuous
- 5 Past perfect
- 6 Conditional sentences
- 7 Modals
- 8 Modals contd.
- 9 Punctuation – a summary
- 10 Preparing and giving a presentation
- 11 Learning styles and study tips
- 12 Job interviews – tips and strategies
- 13 Being assertive
- 14 Getting what you want on the telephone
- 15 Spoken and written language
- 16 Presenting an argument

1 The passive

L1 Unit 2, L2 Unit 1 ◀◀

Use

The passive is used:

- To describe processes.
*After the tobacco leaves **have been picked**, they **are dried**.*
- To convey a more objective tone in news reports.
*Several people **were arrested**. They **will be held** in custody overnight.*
- In more academic and other more formal settings – letters, reports, essays and lectures. *It **is thought** that the cause of the sudden increase in ...*

When the passive is used, you may not know who or what is responsible for the action. The actual event or process is the most important information.

*The car **was stolen** at around midnight.*

Form

To make the passive you simply use the verb **to be** in the appropriate tense and then add the past participle of the main verb.

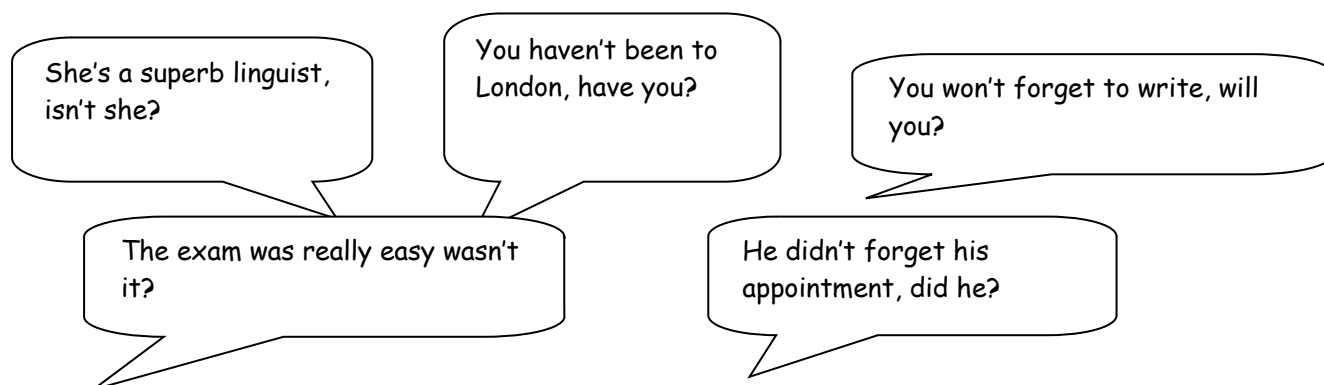
Look at some of the main tenses using the verbs

	Past - passive	Present - passive	Future - passive
Simple	She was divorced last year.	I am married.	He will be married next Spring.
Continuous	She was being driven to the church when the accident happened.	The guests are being taken to the church in hire cars.	*****
Perfect	They had been married for four years when their first child was born.	She has been married before.	They will have been married for six years next summer.
Perfect continuous	They had been living together for some time.	*****	*****

**** Notice that some continuous tenses are generally not used in the passive voice, only in the active.**

2 Question tags

L1,L2◀



Use

We use question tags to:

- confirm information
- check information

The difference in meaning is shown in the intonation of the question.

Use a falling intonation to indicate a confirming question tag.

You're Joe's sister, aren't you? →

This means I'm almost sure you are Joe's sister and I expect you to agree with me.

You're Joe's sister, aren't you? ↗

This means I'm not sure if you are Joe's sister, and I want you to tell me if I am correct.

Form

- Question tags are formed with the auxiliary verb. They go at the end of the main sentence.
- You use a negative question tag with a positive sentence.
 - *It was a lovely day, wasn't it?*
 - *You'll be 30 next birthday, won't you?*
- You use a positive question tag with a negative sentence.
 - *You don't like me, do you?*
 - *You won't forget to tell her, will you?*

Common errors

Getting a mismatch between the verb tense in the main part of the sentence and the tag question and in particular, the over-use of the tag question *isn't it?*

It'll be difficult, isn't it? ✗ *It'll be difficult, won't it?* ✓

3 Connectives

L2 Unit 2 ◀◀

Use

Connectives are words or phrases used to connect different parts of a written text or a section of more extended spoken language. They make connections between different clauses, sentences and paragraphs so that the ideas expressed in the text or spoken piece link together. Connectives include conjunctions e.g. *and*, *but*, *or*, *so* connecting adverbs e.g. *however*, *then*, *therefore*, *in addition* or prepositional phrases e.g. *in other words*, *after all* *that*.

Form

Connectives can be grouped under particular functions. These groups will often be used in particular types of text.

Function or purpose	Connectives
To organize information e.g. in narrative, instructions	firstly, secondly, finally
To add more information e.g. in explanations, analysis of problems	and also, even more important, another factor is, in addition, furthermore, moreover, more importantly
To give reasons or causes e.g. when presenting arguments, persuading	one of the (main) causes is, the (second major) cause is, because, as, as a result of, consequently
To show contrast e.g. in justification, explanations	however, but, even though, although, on the other hand, despite this
To introduce an example e.g. in reporting results, explanations	for example, for instance, such as
To show the result of actions e.g. summarising proposals	as a result, because (of this), so, therefore, consequently, that's why

Examples:

- **Firstly**, I would like to draw your attention to ...
- Profits for the first quarter are up by 7%. **Furthermore**, productivity has increased by the same rate.
- **One of the main causes of** increased productivity is
- Your work has improved greatly over the year. **Despite this**, you still have a lot of work to do if you are going to pass your exams.
- There are many reasons why her health has improved. **For instance**, she recently lost a large amount of weight.
- She has lost weight. **Consequently**, her health has improved.

Note: Pronouns can also function as connectives by referring back to the subject in a previous sentence.

A survey of adult learners will take place shortly. It will be the largest ever.

4 Present perfect continuous

L1 Unit 4◀

What have you been doing?
I've been waiting for half an hour.

I see Joel has been getting into trouble again.

You have been recording this programme, haven't you?

Use

You use the present perfect continuous to:

- describe a state or action which began in the past and is still continuing or is about to finish. This tense emphasises the continuing time period.
- describe an action which continued up to the recent past and you can still see the results. e.g. *You've been fighting again.*
- with some verbs to suggest an action continuing into the present e.g.
I've read your book. (I've finished)
I've been reading your book. (I'm still reading it)

Form

- You use the auxiliary verb **have/has + been + verb + ing**

Positive	Leila has been living in Bristol for two years. I'm exhausted. I've been travelling all night.
Negative	He hasn't (has not) been doing very well on his course so he's leaving. We 've (have) been working for more than two hours.
Question	Has Ali been doing his coursework? Have you been getting ready? We need to leave soon.

- As with the present perfect, you use *for* to describe the period of time the action has continued for and use *since* to describe the point in time when the action started.

*I've been teaching **for** 20 years.*

*Wegdi has been living in the UK **since** 1999.*

***For** how long have Theodette and Maca been sharing a flat?*

- As with other tenses, some verbs are not normally used in the continuous.

I've been knowing her for years. x I've known her for years. 4

They've been loving living here. x They've loved living here. 4

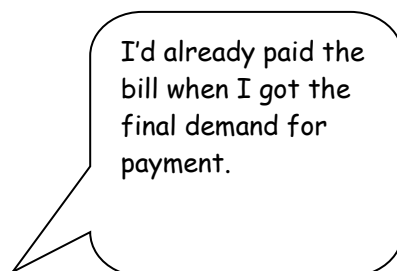
He hasn't been understanding the news. x He hasn't understood the news. 4

5 Past perfect

L1 Unit 2◀

After the lorry had shed it's load, the road was closed. the

What exams had you done before you came here?



Use

- Action 1 Action 2
(had done) (did) Now
- ↓ ↓ ↓
- You use the past perfect to describe something that happened before another action or event in the past. It can be seen as a 'double past'.
*I went to meet Sau Chun, but she **had** already **gone**.*
*We went to Ireland last year. We **had been** there twice before.*
*He died last year. How long **had** he **been** ill?*
 - The past perfect is the past equivalent of the present perfect:
*I'm hungry because I **haven't** eaten. → I **was** hungry because I **hadn't** eaten.*

Form

- Form the past perfect like this: **noun + had + past participle**

Positive	Leila had lived in Bristol for several months before she found a job. I'd (had) been up all night so I was exhausted.
Negative	He left college last summer because he'd (had) failed his end of year exams. By six o'clock they still hadn't (had not) heard from her, so they decided to leave without her.
Question	Had he had much practice before he took his driving test? Where had he left his coat?

Note: The Past Perfect Continuous is the equivalent of the Present Perfect Continuous.

*I **have been waiting** for ages (now) → I **had been waiting** for ages when she finally arrived.*

6 Conditional sentences

L2 Unit 2 ◀◀

You use conditional sentences to describe situations which are true in certain circumstances or under certain conditions. They are made up of two clauses. One clause usually has *if* at the beginning.

General truths - for things that are always true. (zero conditional)

Present simple	if	Present simple
<i>Water freezes</i>		<i>you heat it below zero.</i>
<i>You can't drive alone</i>		<i>you don't pass your driving test.</i>

Possible & probable conditions - for things that are very likely to happen.

Present simple	if	Present simple
<i>We'll catch the train</i>		<i>we hurry.</i>
<i>The doctor won't see you</i>		<i>you don't have an appointment.</i>

Possible but improbable conditions - for things which might happen, but probably won't.

Would (do)	if	Past simple
<i>I'd live in my own flat</i>		<i>I had enough money. (but that's not likely to happen)</i>
<i>She'd be more relaxed</i>		<i>she didn't work so hard. (but she always works too hard)</i>

Impossible conditions - for situations which are in the past and therefore no longer possible.

Would have (done)	if	Past perfect
<i>I'd (would) have gone to the meeting</i>		<i>I had heard about it in time. It's now too late.</i>
<i>You'd have got better marks</i>		<i>you'd spent more time revising.</i>

Note: The *if* clause can be in first or second position.

7 Modals – a summary

L2 Unit 2 ◀◀

The nine main modal verbs are *can, could, may, might, shall, should, will, would, must*. There are other auxiliary verbs - *ought to, used to, dare, need, have to* - which are used in a similar way.

Use

- Modals are auxiliary verbs which combine with the main verb to express a range of meanings such as possibility, obligation, necessity, ability.
- They are never about facts, but about the speaker's or listener's opinion at the time of speaking.

Form and meaning

- You don't use **to** after a modal verb except with *ought to, have to* and *used to*.
*I must **to** go now. x* *I must go now. 4*
- Modals do not use 3rd person -s forms, -ing forms or -ed endings.

Modal	Past	Function	Examples
can	could	offers	<i>I can/could help.</i>
cannot/can't	couldn't	requests	<i>We could do it for you.</i>
		possibility	<i>Can/could you do this for me?</i>
			<i>Can you come tonight?</i>
could	could		<i>You can't park here. There are double yellow lines.</i>
couldn't	couldn't	deduction	<i>He can't be very old.</i>
		ability	<i>He could be about 50.</i>
			<i>She can sing beautifully.</i>
			<i>He could play well when young.</i>
may	might	permission (formal)	<i>May we leave early?</i>
may not	might not (reporting)	speculation	<i>You may leave the room now.</i>
			<i>You may not leave before 10.00.</i>
might	might		<i>It may/might be Ajit over there. I can't see.</i>
might not	might not (reporting)	future possibility	<i>I may go, I'm not sure yet.</i>
			<i>We might see you there.</i>
			<i>He might not be able to get there.</i>
			<i>There may not be time.</i>
will	would	requests	<i>Will you do this again please?</i>
won't (will not)	wouldn't (reporting)	offers	<i>I'll ask him if you like.</i>
		future possibility	<i>It won't arrive in time.</i>
		refusals	<i>It will be quite a difficult journey.</i>
			<i>I won't do that. It's too dangerous.</i>
would	would	requests	<i>Would you pass me the hole punch?</i>
wouldn't	wouldn't (reporting)	advice	<i>What would you do?</i>
		speculation	<i>It would be easier to go by car.</i>

Modal	Past	Function	Examples
shall (negative rarely used)	should	offers	<i>Shall I go and ask her?</i>
	shouldn't (reporting)	suggestions	<i>Who shall we ask to the opening?</i>
should	should	asking for &	<i>What do you think I should do?</i>
shouldn't	shouldn't	giving advice	<i>You should tell the police about it.</i>

	(reporting)		
must	had to	obligation (speaker's view)	<i>You mustn't go out until you're better. I mustn't forget to post this. What must we do to join? He must be tired after the journey.</i>
mustn't	didn't have to	deduction	
ought to	none	obligation - moral	<i>It's late. I ought to ring home. You ought not to park there.</i>
ought not to			
have to	had to	obligation - based on external authority	<i>He had to report to the police station once a week. We don't have to leave the building until 5.00.</i>
don't have to	didn't have to		
need to	needed to	necessity	<i>We don't need to pay. It's free.</i>
needn't / don't need to	didn't need to		<i>I need to speak to him urgently. What do I need to do?</i>

- A past form of modals is used to analyse and speculate about past events.
The auxiliary verb **have** is added to the modal verb.
 - *The council **can't have known** the problems the road scheme would cause.*
 - *They **couldn't have done** much research.*
 - *They **could have built** a by-pass if they had had enough money.*
 - *They **might have thought** fewer people would use cars.*
 - *They **might not have been able** to find an alternative.*
 - *It **would have been** better to invest in more out of town parking.*
 - *It **wouldn't have cost** much extra to include a proper consultation.*
 - *They **should have asked** the shop-keepers.*
 - *They **ought to have done** more research.*
 - *They **must have realised** it would cause problems.*
 - *They **needn't have done** it in such a hurry.*

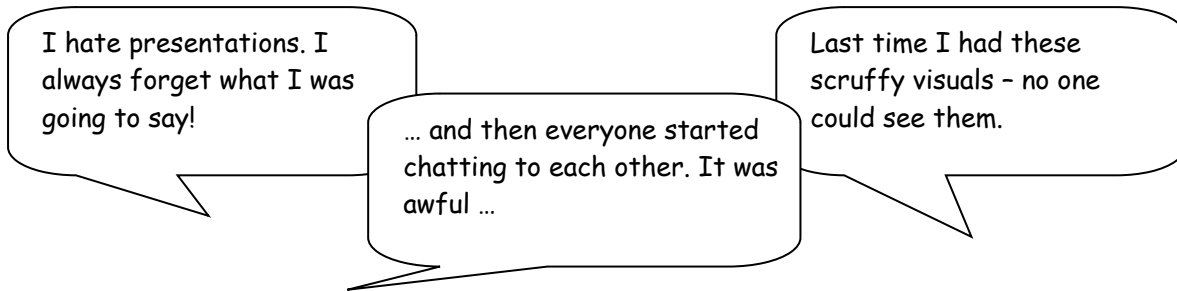
9 Punctuation marks – a summary

L1, L2◀

	Name	Use	Example
.	Full stop	To mark the end of a sentence.	<i>It's my turn.</i>
,	Comma	To separate items in a list. Use and instead of a comma for the last item on the list. To separate parts of a sentence.	<i>I'm going to buy carrots, potatoes, apples and bananas.</i> <i>If I were you, I'd find a new job.</i>
?	Question mark	Used in place of a full stop to indicate a question.	<i>What do you mean?</i>
'	Apostrophe	To show shortened forms and where letters are missing. To show possession.	<i>I'd love another cup of tea.</i> <i>Mark is Nina's husband.</i>
!	Exclamation mark	To show emphasis.	<i>Stop! You're joking! I'm so sorry!</i>
:	Colon	To introduce a list of items.	<i>There are several types of vegetables available: carrots; potato; sweet potatoes.</i>
;	Semi-colon	For separating parts of a long compound sentence when the sentence already contains commas.	<i>See the above example.</i>
- .	Dash or Bullet points	Use when emphasising a list of items or series of points when laying out text. To start a new line.	<i>The following must be completed before the store is closed:</i> <i>- sweep floors</i> <i>- secure all exits</i> <i>- empty till.</i>
-	Hyphen	Used to join the parts of compound words.	<i>Police are looking for a 19-year-old man.</i>
() []	Brackets	These enclose additional information, less important information, explanations or comments not essential to the main text.	<i>We went on holiday last year to Tunisia with Marina (Arti's friend from college), and my brother.</i>
" "	Speech marks	To enclose direct quotes.	<i>"I think you should leave him this time," said Tina.</i>

10 Preparing a presentation

L1 Unit 1 ◀◀



You often need to give a presentation as part of a course you are on, but the skills involved may be useful in future work contexts too. A presentation involves communicating well with a group of people. You need to know what is involved, and practise in order to do it well.

Preparation and planning

- When planning, really think carefully about what you want to cover.
- Make detailed notes and decide on your introduction, your main points and conclusion.
- Remember to include examples to expand your main points.
- Prepare visual aids to illustrate your talk. Make sure they will be big enough to be seen by your audience and practise how you will display them as you prepare them.
- Highlight key points on your notes, draw up a skeleton plan or transfer more concise notes to file index cards for use during the presentation. Make sure headings and key points are highlighted for easy reference.
- Decide on and note appropriate phrases to introduce each stage. Here are some expressions you may find helpful:
 - ... so in my presentation I'd like to talk about ...
 - My first point is ... My next point is ...
 - So now to my final point.... In conclusion
 - If you have any questions, I'll be happy to try and answer them.
- Rehearse your presentation beforehand. This could be with a friend, or alone. Try standing in front of a mirror. Time yourself. Practise using your visual aid. If necessary test any equipment beforehand.

Giving a presentation

- Have your notes available to refer to while you give your talk, but try not to read them out. If you have practised you should be able to remember what you want to say using your notes to prompt you.
- Stand in an upright but relaxed way, smile and make eye contact with your audience.
- Pause between points and breathe slowly to avoid rushing. Try to project your voice to the people at the back of the room. Use tone and intonation to add interest and expression to what you are saying.
- Don't forget to ask whether there are any questions at the end.

11 Learning styles and study advice L2 Unit 1 ◀◀

The sensory theory of learning styles outlines three learning preferences:

- Visual (seeing)
- Aural (hearing)
- Kinaesthetic (doing)

Here is some study advice related to each learning preference. You may find that advice relating to all three styles is useful.

Visual Learners

- You like lively teachers.
- You like information to be presented in visual form.
- You find it useful to take and organise notes using pictures, flowcharts and diagrams, underlining, highlighting, colours, symbols and so on.
- You find it better to replace words with symbols or initials/abbreviations.

Aural Learners

- You enjoy listening to classes, lectures and tutorials.
- You find it useful to discuss topics with teachers and other learners, to explain new ideas to other people, to use a tape recorder for learning, to read your notes and answers aloud when studying at home.
- You may find it useful to expand your notes after class as you may have been too busy listening to take full notes.

Kinaesthetic Learners

- You enjoy taking part in practical activities, going on trips and visits, and trying to work things out for yourself.
- You learn by taking an active part in role play, discussions and by illustrating ideas with real-life examples. You remember the 'real' things that happen in class.
- You benefit from using all your senses to learn (sight, touch, taste, smell, hearing) by collecting examples, taking photographs, going out and practising.
- You make mistakes and learn from them.

General approaches to study

Think about whether you prefer to:

- Work alone or with others
- Have support or be independent
- Have guidance or work things out for yourself
- Study at home, in a library, with background noise, music, or silence
- Move around while you are thinking or be still

There are many ways of learning and of discovering the best ways for you to learn. You can explore some of the sites on the Internet or look at one of the many Study Skills handbooks. The more you understand and explore your own preferences the more effective you will be as a learner.

12 Job Interviews

L1 Unit 4 ◀◀

Before you even think about applying for a particular post, do your homework and get yourself prepared. Here are some suggestions:

Before the interview

- Research the organisation you are applying to. This will help you understand the context of the job and answer questions more effectively.
- Look carefully at the job description and personnel specification (the section in the job information which outlines what the company is looking for in the successful candidate). Make notes and be prepared for questions on each point.

At the interview

- You can take your notes with you. Put them on cards and ask if you can refer to them in the interview. However, don't read your notes from the card or recite them from memory.
- Take your time to think about the answer to a question if you need to. If you are not sure about a question, ask for clarification. For example, *I'm not sure what you mean by ... – could you explain?* or *Do you mean ...?*
- An interview is your chance to show that you are the right person for the job.
 - Do not give simple yes/no answers.
 - Give direct answers to the questions.
 - Don't ramble or go off the point.
 - Support your answers with examples from your experience.

Yes, I get on very well with people. In my last job, I spent a lot of time dealing with the public. For example, I was often on the customer service desk. I had to deal with queries and complaints. My manager at the time was very complimentary about my communication skills.

- Think about what you **can** do rather than what you can't. Be positive.
Can you use Microsoft Publisher?
No, but I'm very familiar with all aspects of Microsoft Office and I'd be very interested in learning how to use Publisher.
- At the end of an interview, you are usually given the chance to ask questions. Prepare a couple of questions to ask, for example:
What would my main responsibilities be?
Do you provide in-service training?
- Pay attention to body language:
 - Make eye contact with the interviewer(s).
 - Don't fidget, e.g. scratching, playing with your hair and so on.
 - Lean forwards slightly in your chair to appear attentive.
 - Relax and keep calm.

13 Being assertive

L1 Unit 3◀◀

Imagine you chose to sit in a non-smoking compartment on a train because you cannot stand the smell of smoke. Then someone lit a cigarette. What would you do?

Imagine you are waiting in a long queue at the Post Office for 25 minutes when someone pushes in. You are in a hurry yourself. What would you do?

4 *I want you to smoke outside. Smoking makes my asthma worse.*

6 *I'm sorry to be a pain, but do you think you could smoke somewhere else?*

4 *I've been waiting here for 20 minutes. Would you please go to the back of the queue?*

6 *Hey. You've got a cheek pushing in like that when we've all been waiting for ages.*

Assertiveness is about getting what you want. Assertiveness is not about being aggressive or shouting.

To be assertive, you need to:

- Express your ideas without feeling guilty or intimidated.
- Express your needs clearly and directly.
- Understand that you are the equal of others. Talk to people adult to adult.
- Show self-confidence. Stand tall, look others in the eye and relax your body.
- Know what your rights are and how to get them.
- Finally, don't back down at the first hurdle.

You: *I want to talk to the manager.*

Assistant: *I'm sorry, the manager isn't here.*

You: *Then I'd like to talk to whoever is in charge at the moment.*

Assistant: *That's Mr. Baines. He's busy at the moment.*

You: *I'll wait until he's free. It's very important that I speak to someone now.*

Assistant: *OK, perhaps you'd like to wait over there and I'll let him know you're here. Can I take your name?*

14 Getting what you want on the telephone

L1 Unit 3◀◀

Using the telephone to complain or deal with difficult situations can be intimidating. Thinking carefully and planning beforehand will help you get what you want.

Before you ring

- Write down what you want to say.
- Find out who you need to speak to in the organisation.
- Rehearse what you are going to say beforehand. If you think it might be a particularly difficult call, practise with a friend beforehand.

When you ring

- Ask for the correct person by name. If you don't know their name, ask for them by position.
Can I talk to the customer services manager, please?
- Take the name of the person you are talking to.
Who am I talking to? or Could you give me your name please?
- Identify yourself and introduce your reason for ringing.
- If you cannot get through to the right person, leave a message asking them to contact you. Include your name, telephone number and reason for calling.
- If you speak to someone and you are not satisfied, ask to speak to someone else, for example, their manager.
- Ask when you can expect a return call, letter or other action.
- Summarise what has gone on in the conversation with the other person.

So, you're going to refund the cost of the coat to my account by 25th of this month. If that doesn't happen, I should ring you personally. Is that correct?
- Keep a written record of the call, including date, time, name of person you talked to and the agreed action.

15 Spoken and Written English

L1, L2◀

There are some key differences between spoken and written English. It is very important to understand these differences especially in formal writing situations, for example:

Formal letters Reports Memos Essays

Spoken English is usually spontaneous whereas written English is usually planned. Spoken English contains a lot of repetition and moving away from the point, but because writing can be kept and referred back to, it needs to be precise in its meaning. When we speak, we have facial expression, tone of voice, context and body language to help us with meaning, but we only have the words on the page in written English.

Vocabulary

- More formal words in English are of French or Latin origin, whereas more informal everyday words tend to be of Germanic origin. This is because the language of law and rule in the Middle Ages was French.
- Idiom and regional dialect are used a lot in spoken English, but Standard English is used for writing.

Informal: *I got some great presents for my birthday.*

Formal: *I received some wonderful gifts on my birthday.*

Informal: *The kids were full of beans today.*

Formal: *The children were very lively today.*

Informal: *We eat a lot of chips in this country.*

Formal: *A large quantity of chips is consumed in this country.*

Structure

- You stop mid-sentence, change the subject and interrupt when speaking. Spoken English therefore uses less rigid grammar than written English.
- Regional differences in grammar occur in spoken English but not in written English.
I seen him yesterday. (Liverpool English)
I saw him yesterday. (Standard/written English)
- Written English uses more complicated sentence structures than written English.
- We don't usually use contractions such as *I'm*, *he'd*, in written English.
- Written English is generally less personal than spoken English.
 - We don't usually express strong feelings.
 - We don't use so many personal pronouns.
 - We use the *passive* to appear more objective.

Spoken/informal: *We don't use so many personal pronouns.*

Written/formal: *Fewer personal pronouns are used.*

16 Presenting an argument

L1, L2◀◀

- Before you begin to present an argument, verbally or on paper, make sure you are clear about what your argument is and how you can support it.
- Don't assume that everyone else understands your point of view. Explain your point of view clearly and in unemotional language.

X *Filth and pollution from greedy multi-nationals are killing the planet.*

4 *Delegates were told that waste from factories, including those belonging to major multi-national companies, would be responsible for the majority of the climate change predicted over the next 10 years.*

- Use facts to support your argument. For example, "People in Britain are far less interested in marriage than they used to be. (*argument*) Forty per cent of children are born to unmarried mothers today compared to 0.5% in 1953." (*supporting fact*)
- Avoid making vague, general statements such as "*leading doctors say ...*". Be specific, for example, "*Consultant heart surgeon, John Schaffer, said in 1999 that ...*", or "*According to a survey in the medical magazine, The Lancet, 8 out of 10 doctors believe that ...*".
- Use tables, charts and graphs to help construct an argument if you can.
- At the end of your presentation, summarise the main points of your argument again.